

Audio Transcript

Neurodiversity

Introduction

Neurodiversity describes the idea that people experience and interact with the world around them in different ways, there is no one “right” way of thinking, learning, and behaving, and these differences are not to be viewed as deficits.

It is important for all of us to foster an environment that is conducive to neurodiversity. We need to recognize and emphasize each and every person’s individual strengths and talents and provide support for their differences and requirements.

People with neurological differences are not broken or incomplete versions of normal people. We are all born different and raised differently, hence all of us are to some extent, differently abled. Neurodiversity is a normal and natural variation in the human genome. The distinctiveness of neurodiverse people isn’t something that necessarily needs to be “cured”. Neurodiverse employees merely need some help and accommodation. They may bring new perspectives to an organization’s efforts to create or recognize value.

In this course, you will:

- Recognize the value that neurodiverse employees add to an organization.
- You will understand how to educate your employees about neurodiversity and create an inclusive workplace.

- You will learn to examine strategies for providing equal access to neurodiverse employees.
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Neurodiversity in the Workforce

The neurodiverse population remains a largely untapped pool of talent. Unemployment runs as high as 80%. Even when they are working, highly capable neurodiverse people are often underemployed. Many times, despite having required skill sets and solid credentials, they have to settle for menial jobs. These poor numbers are due to the way companies screen and hire their possible candidates.

Fostering an inclusive workplace begins with making neurodiversity a priority. Employers and recruiters need to revamp their hiring practices so as to not miss out on any of the neurodiverse talent that could help the company flourish. Recruitment of people on the spectrum is only the first step. Employers need to make certain accommodations for a fulfilling work environment for people across the spectrum.

Encouraging neurodiversity makes organizations inclusive and innovative. Employees who identify on the neurodiverse spectrum bring with them new ways of looking at things. This encourages the entire team to think creatively. Merging unique perspectives and ideas within a team naturally fosters an environment that is innovative and forward-thinking.

Advantages of Neurodiversity at the Workplace

Managers claim that inclusive practices are already showing benefits in ways far beyond reputational enhancement. These include productivity gains, quality improvement, boost in innovative capabilities, and growth in employee engagement. They have begun thinking more deeply about leveraging the talents of all employees through greater sensitivity to individual needs.

1. **Better Pattern Recognition**

Large companies, particularly tech companies have realized they already had neurodiverse talent on their staff. Many of these employees contribute their special skills in pattern recognition, memory, or mathematics on teams working to solve highly complex problems. In the fields of machine learning, artificial intelligence, and data science, neurodiverse employees have proven to outperform their neurotypical counterparts.

2. **Creative Thinking**

Variations in their neurological constitution allows neurodivergent employees to think differently or out of the box. They are able to see past the conventional frameworks which could limit the creativity of neurotypical individuals.

3. **Positive Work Environment/Organization's Reputation**

According to Training Industry, employers who have opened their doors to a neurodiverse workforce have found that neurodiverse and autistic employees have a retention rate upwards of 90%.

Moreover, having neurodiverse talent in your workforce improves a company's external as well as internal image. When a brand has a strong purpose consumers are four times more likely to trust the company, and six times more likely to defend the company from criticism.

Accommodations for Neurodivergent Employees

Organizations as well as employees can benefit from creating a thoughtfully designed accessible workspace. It opens up a creative sandbox where people are free to think, work and create in a way that works best for them.

1. **Inclusive Recruiting**

For people on the neurodiversity spectrum, interviews can be a challenge because their communication styles are not similar to those of neurotypical candidates. The robust communication and eye contact the recruiters and employers look for is not the strong suit of candidates on the spectrum. Try to diversify your hiring strategy.

Psychometric assessments are far more objective as they eliminate human biases in early stages of recruitment. Provide multiple opportunities to candidates so they can demonstrate their ability and competency during the process, regardless of neurodiversity. Formalize a hiring program to help create a talent pipeline of neurodivergent candidates.

2. **Distraction-free Environment**

Provide a distraction-free workspace to employees, for example noise cancelling headphones to reduce sensory overload and spacious drawers and storage cabinets to declutter their desks. Distraction need not necessarily be physical. Mental decluttering is also as important. Provide reference materials, worksheets, and interview questions in advance and have sufficient mental health days in your company calendar. Assistive technologies can help some neurodivergent employees to perform better. Such support can include software and devices like portable and talking word processors, assistive listening systems and visual organizers.

3. **Architectural Accommodations**

You can create focused areas of work where employees — neurodiverse or neurotypical can choose to work with low stimuli. Assess the texture of desks, chairs, and any other high-touch surfaces. Spatial disorientation can frustrate people with dyslexia and autism. So, try to create unique spaces with visual landmarks and clear lines of sight that can help everyone map their own location within a space, ultimately saving both time and frustration. Arranging furniture in different ways can also help people feel better equipped at work. The same positioning of the desk might not be comfortable for everyone. So, allow a space where pacing is welcomed.

4. Flexibility

Consider giving your employees the option of remote working. Flexible work schedules support your entire workforce and not just neurodivergent employees — working parents, caregivers and people with disability.

5. Empowering Language

Neurodiversity advocates encourage inclusive, non-judgmental language. While many disability advocacy organizations prefer person-first language (“a person with autism”, “a person with Down syndrome”), some research has found that the majority of the autistic community prefers identity-first language (“an autistic person”). Therefore, rather than making assumptions, it is best to ask directly what a person’s preferred language is and how they want to be addressed.

6. Educate Your Team

Create a culture where individuals feel comfortable to disclose and talk openly about their neurodiversity. Upskill your workforce by providing ‘Diversity and Inclusion Training days’ for all so that everyone understands the challenges and the uniqueness of neurodiversity. Focus on fostering an open and trusting relationship with your team. Ask the employees what support they need. Provide employees additional support and guidance, if required, and ensure to make employees aware of the availability of the same. Ensure other team members are aware of the specific needs each individual may require. Moreover, handle performance issues very sensitively.

If you feel uncertain about anything, you can begin by asking your employees what they feel is required for them to work efficiently and comfortably. Your employees do not have to reveal their medical history for you to make accommodations at the workplace. You can simply ask them to share which elements of their work experience could be made more inclusive or accessible.

Summary

By the end of this course, you have learned:

- Neurodiversity describes the idea that people experience and interact with the world around them in many different ways, there is no one “right” way of thinking, learning, and differences should not be viewed as deficits.
- You learned that the neurodiverse population remains a largely untapped pool of talent and they have the ability to bring in new perspectives. You learned that neurodivergent employees are proven to have better pattern recognition and creative thinking than their neurotypical counterparts. Plus, accommodating neurodivergent candidates can greatly improve a company’s image.
- You learned that people managers must practice inclusive recruiting with, for example, psychometric assessment or performance-based tests, so as not to miss out on neurodivergent talent.
- You learned that leaders must accommodate neurodivergent employees by creating distraction-free workspaces, providing flexibility, and educating themselves and their teams about the challenges and uniqueness of the people on the spectrum.